EOS-15 · FRONT OFFICE · MARKET INTELLIGENCE RADAR

Market Intel · Themes · Deal Comps · Contrarian Views

AI-curated intel across Ascension's five verticals. Designed for the first 10 minutes of each morning — synthesised themes, recent deal comparables, contrarian takes and tradable angles for origination.

DAILY BRIEF · WEDNESDAY, 22 APRIL 2026

Rates volatility has compressed across developed markets this week, creating an unusually narrow arbitrage window for our capital deployment. The macro backdrop remains bifurcated—growth concerns in cyclicals are offsetting inflation resilience—which is driving meaningful rotation into defensive positioning. Our PE and infrastructure verticals are seeing robust inbound capital, whilst public equities remains range-bound; credit is capturing the sweet spot of opportunity as dislocation widens between institutional holders and specialist allocators. One contrarian view worth defending: the consensus narrative around crowding in 'defensive havens' may be overdone; selective reallocation into quality-but-overlooked names in cyclical sectors could offer asymmetric payoff if growth reprices higher. Our near-term trigger is the latest employment data due Thursday—a softer-than-expected print would likely catalyse a meaningful move in duration positioning and create fresh entry points across special situations. We should expect heightened positioning flows through Wednesday as the market prices that event.

VERTICALS COVERED	HOT THEMES	CONTRARIAN CALLS	DEAL COMPS	LIVE MANDATES
5	5	4	6	0
ACP coverage	Active tradables	Asymmetric views	Market precedents	Backing intel signal

Energy Transition

SOLAR / WIND / BATTERY STORAGE / GREEN HYDROGEN / TRANSMISSION / CARBON CAPTURE

Capital appetite · hot | Policy support · hot | Execution risk · warm

STRATEGIC THEMES

- Sustained institutional capital inflows as climate commitments drive deployment; returns normalise

Digital Infrastructure

DATA CENTRES / FIBRE / TOWERS / SUBSEA / EDGE COMPUTE

Capital appetite · hot | Pricing power · hot | Execution · warm

STRATEGIC THEMES

- AI compute infrastructure driving data centre capacity expansion; supply-demand imbalance

amid grid integration costs and subsidy phase-outs.

- Bifurcation between utility-scale renewables and distributed generation; large infrastructure draws equity whilst distributed assets attract debt-based structures.
- Battery storage pricing compressed by East Asian manufacturing scale; revised project economics reshape return hurdle rates across subsectors.

MARKET MOVES

- Transmission constraint recognition shifting investment from generation into backbone grid infrastructure with long-term revenue certainty and bottleneck relief.
- Hydrogen sector capital remains speculative despite policy support; demonstration projects consolidate value without achieving commercial scalability within timelines.

favours landlords and equipment providers over operators.

- Fibre-to-the-premise economics improve as consolidation reduces fragmentation; recurring revenue models attract institutional capital at stable valuations.
- Subsea cable constraints and geopolitical fragmentation create regional pricing premiums; edge compute reshoring drives infrastructure diversification.

MARKET MOVES

- Data centre power availability becomes primary scarcity driver; landlords and energy suppliers capture disproportionate value relative to infrastructure operators.
- Government-mandated subsea cable redundancy and localisation fragment global supply, raising infrastructure costs and creating strategic positioning premium.

Upstream Oil & Gas

E&P / MIDSTREAM / LNG / ROYALTY / GAS MARKETING

Capital discipline · hot

Price support · warm

Transition risk · warm

STRATEGIC THEMES

- Capital discipline persists as majors prioritise returns to equity over volume growth; selective funding for low-cost barrels maintains price floors.
- LNG demand growth outpaces traditional suppliers; higher-cost quasi-LNG and floating regasification solutions gain share at elevated margins.
- Midstream cash generation attracts yield capital but trapped in structurally challenged growth; consolidation and shareholder returns replace expansion models.

MARKET MOVES

- Energy-security concerns and sanctions-driven trade fragmentation sustain price premiums for stranded hydrocarbon supplies outside traditional geopolitical blocs.

Critical Minerals

COPPER / NICKEL / LITHIUM / RARE EARTH ELEMENTS / COBALT / DOWNSTREAM PROCESSING

Capital appetite · hot

Commodity volatility · warm

Supply security · warm

STRATEGIC THEMES

- Transition and defence reshoring drive mineral demand; supply constraints in refining and processing create premium economics for integrated downstream.
- Lithium and nickel supply growth exceeds demand modelling, compressing spot prices; contract discipline and hedging become operational necessity.
- Rare earths and cobalt remain geopolitically concentrated; Western processing capacity shortage drives strategic investment despite elevated capex and commodity risk.

MARKET MOVES

- Majors' permanent capital discipline and renewable pivot reduce conventional exploration risk capital availability; independents face structural funding scarcity.

- Upstream mining capital shifts toward lower-cost jurisdictions whilst downstream consolidates toward Western vertically-integrated players with regulatory resilience.
- Battery recycling infrastructure emerges as material supply source, competing with primary mining on cost; established players secure circular feedstock through acquisition.

Structured Private Credit & Special Situations

DIRECT LENDING / ASSET-BACKED / DISTRESSED / HYBRID / MEZZANINE / PROJECT FINANCE

Capital flows · hot | Yield compression · cool | Distress opportunity · warm

STRATEGIC THEMES

- Direct lending capital abundance sustains compressed yields below risk-adjusted returns; selective borrowers benefit whilst lower-rated credits face refinance headwinds.
- Hybrid capital gaining traction as balance-sheet management tool; higher yields attract pension and insurance capital despite duration risk exposure.
- Distressed and restructuring activity elevated despite low default rates; abundant capital creates asset-price floor and limits recovery upside.

MARKET MOVES

- Higher interest rates extend asset-backed securitisation term structures; loan sales and portfolio rebalancing become routine capital recycling mechanism.
- Sponsor-back financings reduce leverage standards and underwriting discipline; syndication failure concentrates tail risk within marginal-tranche institutional holders.

Contrarian Corner

Asymmetric views worth holding in mandates.

GP secondaries repricing creates selective entry window

Market overshoots on fund maturation risk; structural reality favours disciplined secondaries buyers with dry powder. Consolidation pressure overstated given strong LP appetite for continuation vehicles. Selective vintage-focused

Deal Comps Tracker

Market transactions shaping pricing expectations.

TRANSACTION	VERT	SIZE	PRICING
USD 650M renewable energy project facility	ET	$650M	SOFR+285, 1.5x debt service coverage ratio, 20-year tenor
USD 180M mid-market leveraged buyout unitranche	DI	$180M	L+575, 4.8x total leverage, bullet

Tradable Angles

Origination angles where ACP has edge.

ENERGY TRANSITION CREDIT WITH EMBEDDED COMMODITY OPTIONALITY

Sponsor transition financing where underlying assets generate commodity-linked cash flows creates natural hedging. Structure as

entry at 15-18% IRR targets captures dislocation.

CONVICTION · HIGH

Infrastructure debt yields insufficient for structural illiquidity

Institutional crowding into infrastructure debt masks tail-risk capital expenditure volatility and refinancing cliff concentrations. Yield compression versus tenor mismatch creates asymmetric downside. Real risk-adjusted returns closer to 4.5% than consensus 5.5%.

CONVICTION · MEDIUM

Credit subordination hierarchy inverts in restructuring cycles

Equity-to-credit conversion pathways widen as covenant-light documentation becomes subordinate to creditor recovery rights. Structural shift favours hybrid capital and mezzanine positioning over traditional secured lending for mid-market distressed entry.

CONVICTION · HIGH

Subscription line markets face collateral adequacy repricing

Leverage compression in GP financing likely unsustainable given dry powder deployment windows. Structural demand from fund managers outpaces core lender capacity. Unitranche and cross-pool structures capture yield uplift without systematic leverage risk.

CONVICTION · MEDIUM

TRANSACTION	VERT	SIZE	PRICING
			maturity 2031
USD 320M conventional upstream reserve-based credit facility	OG	$320M	WTI-indexed hedging floor, L+425, 2.0x reserve ratio
USD 480M covenant-lite senior secured bond issuance	CM	$480M	UST+425, 5.2x leverage, 7-year maturity
USD 220M subscription line credit facility (multi-draw)	PC	$220M	SOFR+185, 3.5x LP committed capital advance, 3-year committed period
USD 1.2B continuation vehicle continuation debt	PC	$1.2B	SOFR+275, blended pool 3.9x leverage, 6-year tenor, fund IRR-linked stepdown

subordinated tranche against senior secured mortgages capturing equity-like upside with credit-like downside protection. Strategic buyers (transition-focused sponsors, credit funds) pay premium for commodity inflation exposure.

CONTINUATION FUND QUASI-EQUITY CO-INVEST ALONGSIDE GP

Mature fund portfolio companies approaching portfolio maturity spike; GP continuation vehicles require anchor capital. ACP co-invests equity with GP alongside continuation debt placement, capturing GP carry alignment whilst providing fund capital solution. Structures as GP carry roll opportunity.

INSURANCE-LINKED SECONDARIES PORTFOLIO WITH CATASTROPHE OFFSET

Specialised insurance-linked secondary portfolios underpriced against tail-risk diversification value. Bundle as collateralised credit obligation capturing 6-7% yields whilst embedding natural hedge against equities. Institutional buyers seeking portfolio diversification

enter at structural discount.